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Abu Dhabi and Dubai: a clear guide for your AED 2M

There's a lot of noise about the UAE property market right now, and much of it contradicts itself. This guide cuts it down to what actually matters for your budget: how the two cities compare, what protects your money, and which homes make sense.

The short version

- Both cities are safe, regulated places to buy. Which one suits you depends on what you want the home to do for you.
- **Dubai** is the bigger, more established market, with more choice and more homes being completed right now.
- **Abu Dhabi** is earlier in its story: more people arriving than homes being built, and payment plans that ask for less money before you receive the keys.

What's happening in each market

	ABU DHABI	DUBAI
Home sales, first half of 2026	Up 178% on last year	Down 16% on last year
New homes coming	Around 37,000 over the next four years	Around 27,300 completed in one quarter this year
People arriving	Around 288,000 in a year - roughly 18 for every new home sold	Roughly 2 for every new home sold
Rents	Up 17% in a year, 21% on the islands	Steadying, with some prices easing 5-7%
Paid before you get the keys	Usually 35-50%	Usually 60-80%
Who stands behind the developers	The government's sovereign funds, around US$1.9 trillion	Dubai's government holding company, Dubai Holding

What protects your money - in both cities

Escrow. Your payments go into a regulated account, not to the developer, and are released only as construction progresses and is verified.

Established developers. Every developer in this guide is government-backed or among the UAE's largest.

Staged payments. You never pay the full price up front - you pay in steps as the building goes up.

Registered ownership. Your purchase is recorded with the government land registry from day one.

Five terms, in plain English

Off-plan - buying a home before it's finished, usually at a lower price.

Payment plan (e.g. 40/60) - 40% paid during construction, 60% when you receive the keys.

Handover - the day the home is finished and yours to use or rent.

Cancellation unit - a home released back to the developer and offered again, often the only way into a project that has sold out.

Escrow - the protected account your payments sit in while the building goes up.

Sources: Cavendish Maxwell H1 2026 · Knight Frank · SCAD · ADREC H1 2026 · Savills Q2 2026. Figures indicative, November 2026.

◆ YOUR OPTIONS IN ABU DHABI

Five homes around your budget, each suited to a different priority.

HOME	WHERE	WHAT YOU GET	PRICE	PAID BEFORE KEYS	READY
The Artery Residences IMKAN	Makers District, Reem Island, on the waterfront	1-bed ~790-830 sq ft, or 2-bed ~1,130-1,170 sq ft	1-bed from ~AED 1.5-1.6m · 2-bed from ~AED 2.3m	40%	Late 2029
Tara Park MODON	Reem Island, opposite Reem Mall, 5 minutes from the financial district	2-bed apartment, from ~1,300 sq ft	~AED 2.4-2.7m	40%	Late 2029 - mid 2030
The Canopies, Yas Point ALDAR	Yas Island waterfront	1-bed ~870 sq ft	from AED 2.2m	To be confirmed	To be confirmed
Manchester City Yas Residences OHANA	Yas Canal	1-bed ~810 sq ft	~AED 1.7-2.0m	50%	2028-29
Bashayer MODON	Hudayriyat Island, on the beach	1-bed ~880 sq ft	from ~AED 2.5m	50%	2029

A note on availability. Tara Park, Manchester City Yas Residences and Bashayer all sold out at launch. For these, we'd be securing a cancellation unit, so availability and exact price are confirmed home by home. The Artery and The Canopies are still selling directly.

Which suits you

IF RENTAL INCOME MATTERS MOST

Tara Park. Its tenants are the professionals working in Abu Dhabi's financial district, which grew 34% in a year. A 2-bedroom here costs about what a 1-bedroom does in much of Dubai. I bought one myself in April.

IF YOU WANT THE BEST VALUE ON A BRAND-NEW LAUNCH

The Artery. A waterfront address in Makers District, beside a 1km promenade with over 100 shops and restaurants planned, at one of the lowest entry prices on the island.

IF YAS ISLAND IS THE DRAW

The Canopies or Manchester City Yas Residences. Yas hotels were 85% full in August, the quietest month of the year - strong ground for holiday lets.

IF YOU'D STRETCH FOR THE BEACH

Bashayer. A beachfront apartment on Abu Dhabi's flagship island, with the surf park and beach already open.

> **Or two homes instead of one.** AED 2m also covers two studios at The Artery, from around AED 900,000 each. Two rents, and the freedom to sell one without selling both.

Prices from developer releases and current listings, November 2026. Indicative and subject to availability.

◆ THE DUBAI OPTION, AND WHERE I'D START

There are good projects in Dubai at this budget, and we can look at them together. To give you something concrete to compare against, here's one idea.

Valia - Emaar, Dubai Creek Harbour

THE ADDRESS
Next to the future Dubai Square mall, from Dubai's best-known developer

1-BED
~820 sq ft from around AED 1.96-2.06m (about AED 2,400-2,500 per sq ft)

PAYMENT PLAN
20% a year from 2026 to 2030 - around 80% paid before you receive the keys

READY
2030

WHY PEOPLE LIKE IT
Emaar's name and a prime Creek Harbour address

WHAT TO WEIGH UP
Most of the price paid before handover, and around a third more per square foot than the Abu Dhabi options

As the numbers on the first page show, Abu Dhabi is probably the safer investment right now - and at this budget, the difference in what you get is clear.

Three homes around AED 2m, side by side

	VALIA · DUBAI	THE ARTERY · ABU DHABI	TARA PARK · ABU DHABI
What you get	1-bed, ~820 sq ft	1-bed, ~790-830 sq ft	2-bed, ~1,300 sq ft
Price	~AED 1.96-2.06m	~AED 1.5-1.6m	~AED 2.4m
Price per sq ft	~AED 2,400-2,500	~AED 1,900-1,960	~AED 1,830
Paid before keys	~AED 1.6m (80%)	~AED 0.6m (40%)	~AED 0.95m (40%)
Ready	2030	Late 2029	Late 2029 - mid 2030

> **WHERE I'D START**
>
> For around the same money, Dubai buys you a 1-bedroom; Abu Dhabi buys you a 1-bedroom with change left over, or a 2-bedroom. You'd also pay far less before the keys arrive, and you'd be buying in a market where many more people are arriving than homes are being built. Valia is a good product from a strong developer - but if I were in your position, I'd start in Abu Dhabi.

What happens next

1
Meet and discuss what you'd like the property to do for you

2
Get the actual unit details on the ones we like - availability, exact prices, floor plans

3
Decide from there whether it makes sense

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Prices and figures indicative as of November 2026, based on developer releases, regulator data and current listings; subject to availability and change. Not financial advice.